

Building Better Slides via Principles of Design



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Adam A Miller
Northwestern/CIERA/SkAI
LSST-DA DSFP Session 26
25 August 2026

Your Brain Is Not a Multiprocessor

I dare you - read all this *and* listen to me

Nacirema culture is characterized by a highly developed market economy which has evolved in a rich natural habitat. While much of the people's time is devoted to economic pursuits, a large part of the fruits of these labors and a considerable portion of the day are spent in ritual activity. The focus of this activity is the human body, the appearance and health of which loom as a dominant concern in the ethos of the people. While such a concern is certainly not unusual, its ceremonial aspects and associated philosophy are unique.

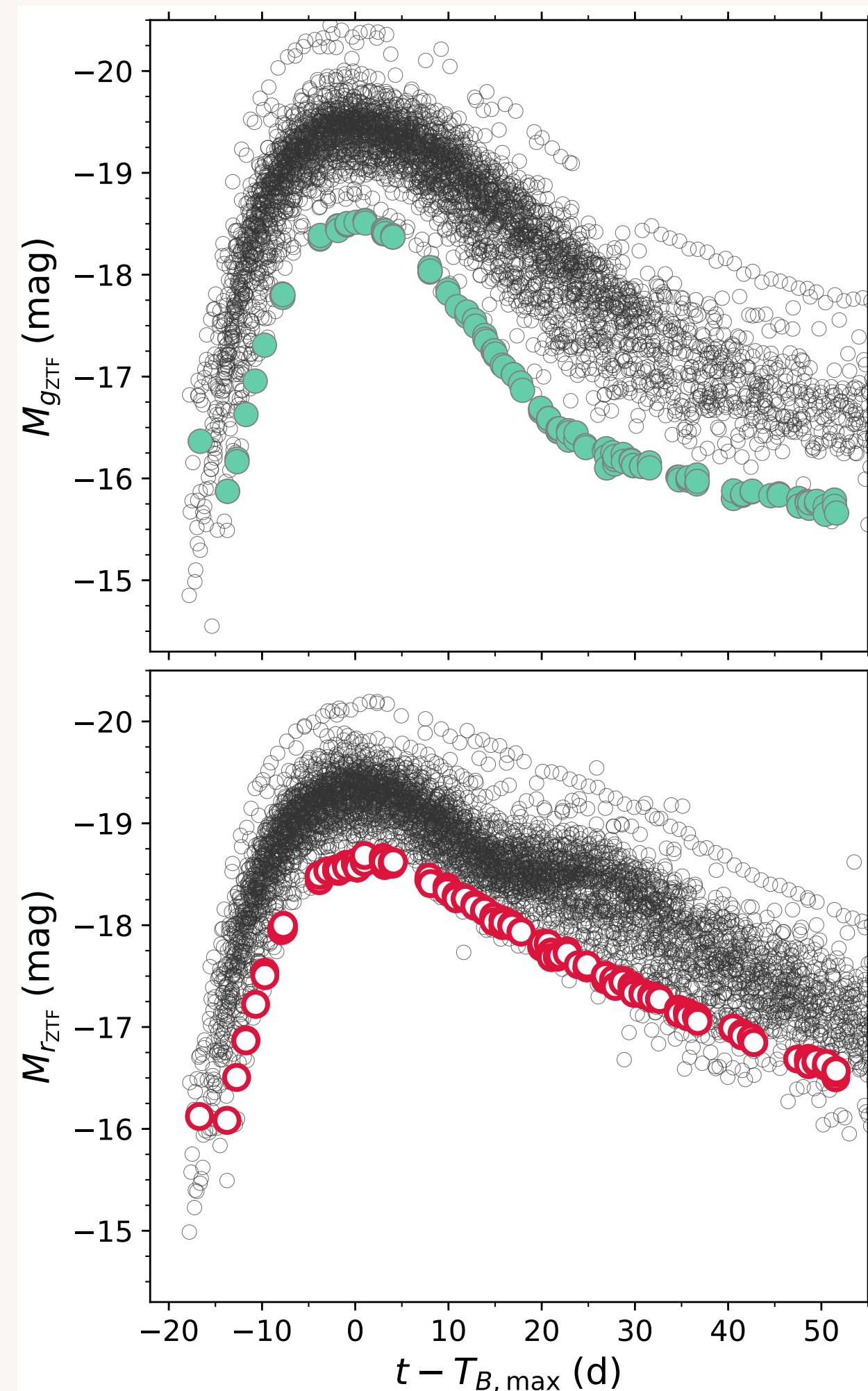
The fundamental belief underlying the whole system appears to be that the human body is ugly and that its natural tendency is to debility and disease. Incarcerated in such a body, man's only hope is to avert these characteristics through the use of the powerful influences of ritual and ceremony. Every household has one or more shrines devoted to this purpose. The more powerful individuals in the society have several shrines in their houses and, in fact, the opulence of a house is often referred to in terms of the number of such ritual centers it possesses. Most houses are of wattle and daub construction, but the shrine rooms of the more wealthy are walled with stone. Poorer families imitate the rich by applying pottery plaques to their shrine walls.

While each family has at least one such shrine, the rituals associated with it are not family ceremonies but are private and secret. The rites are normally only discussed with children, and then only during the period when they are being initiated into these mysteries. I was able, however, to establish sufficient rapport with the natives to examine these shrines and to have the rituals described to me.

The local point of the shrine is a box or chest which is built into the wall. In this chest are kept the many charms and magical potions without which no native believes he could live. These preparations are secured from a variety of specialized practitioners. The most powerful of these are the medicine men, whose assistance must be rewarded with substantial gifts. However, the medicine men do not provide the curative potions for their clients. but decide what the ingredients should be and then write them down in an ancient and secret language. This writing is understood only by the medicine men and by the herbalists who, for another gift, provide the required charm.

Figures

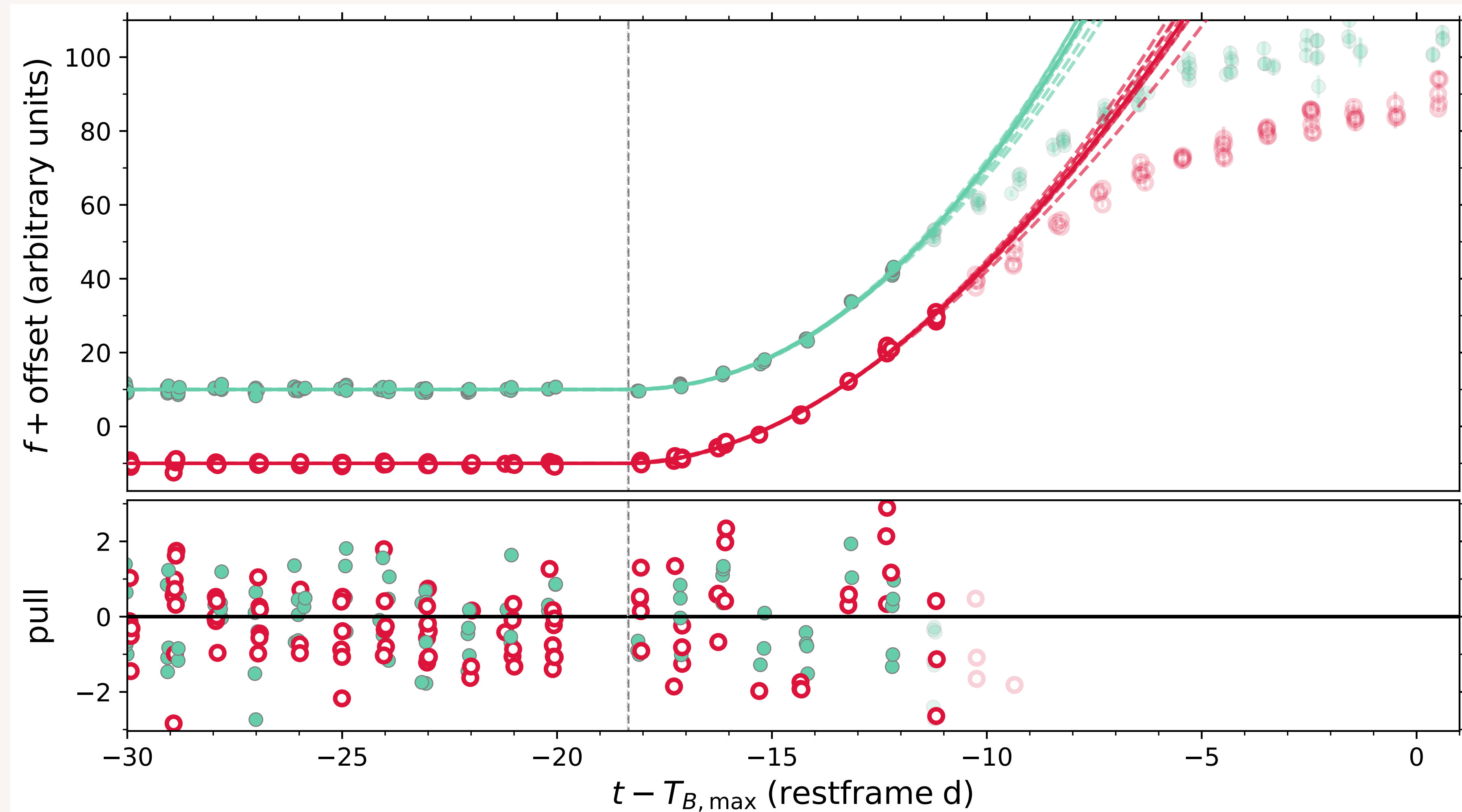
Vertical looks great in (2 column) papers



Look at all this floating
empty space

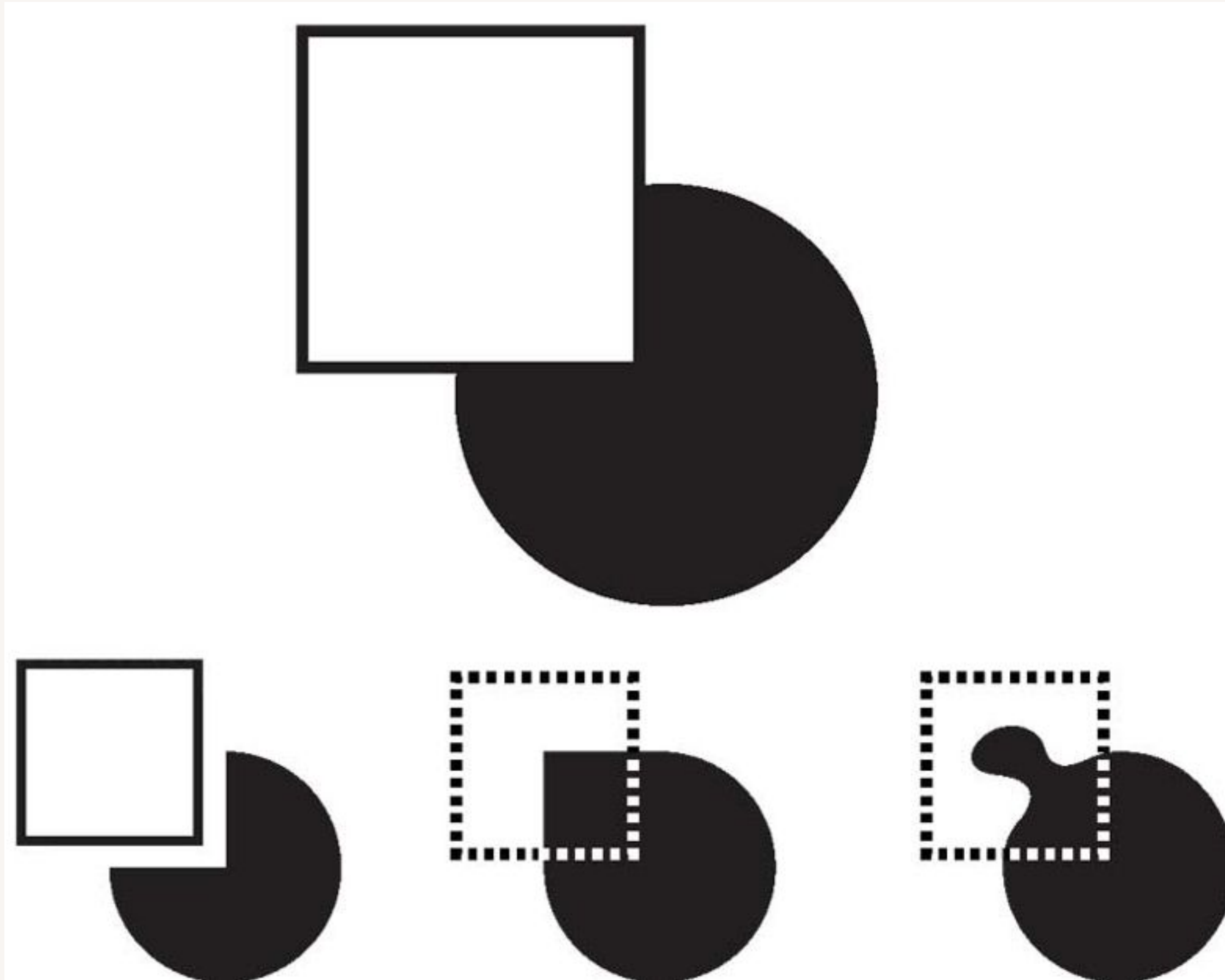
Figures

Horizontal is much better for 16:9



Use Gestalt

Use Gestalt to your advantage



leverage neuroscience research to
encourage automatic “hidden” connections

Use Gestalt

E.g., bullet points

- do you actually need
- individual bullet points
- to separate different thoughts

do you actually need

individual bullet points

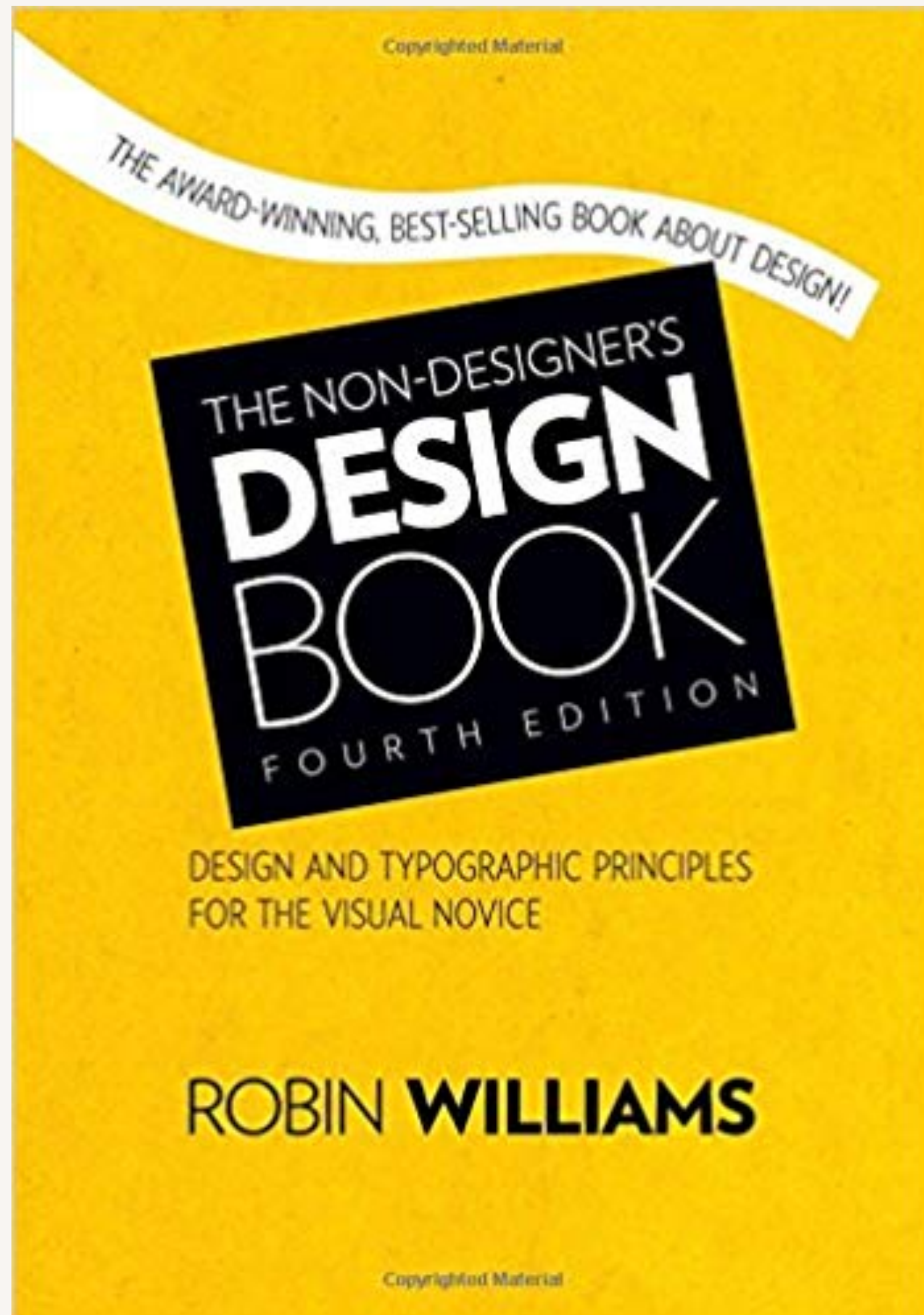
to separate different thoughts

do you actually need

individual bullet points

to separate different thoughts

Four Principles of Design



The Non-designers Design Book, by Robin Williams

Four Principles of Design

Proximity

Ralph Roister Doister

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916 Bread Street

London, NM

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Alignment

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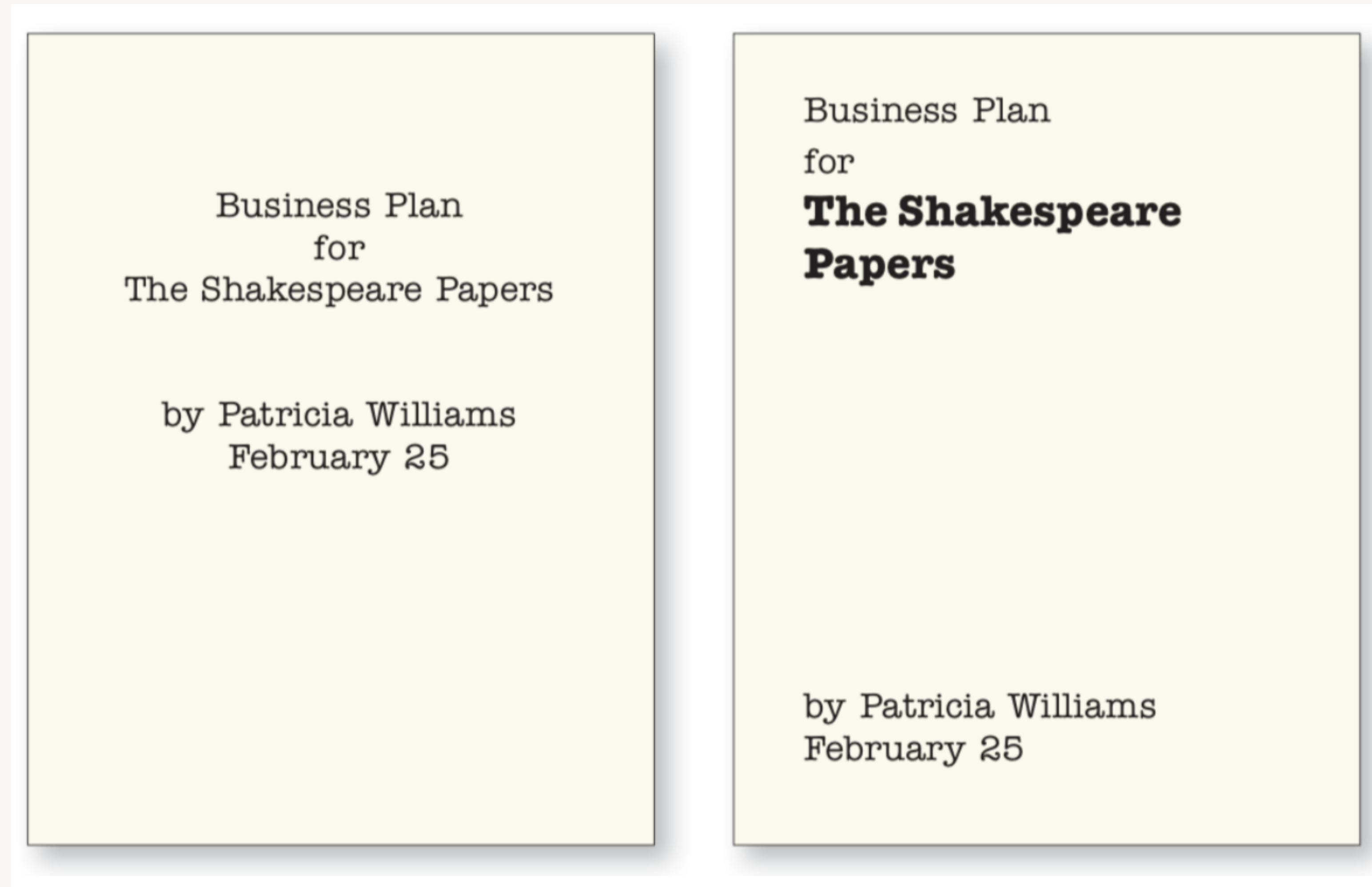
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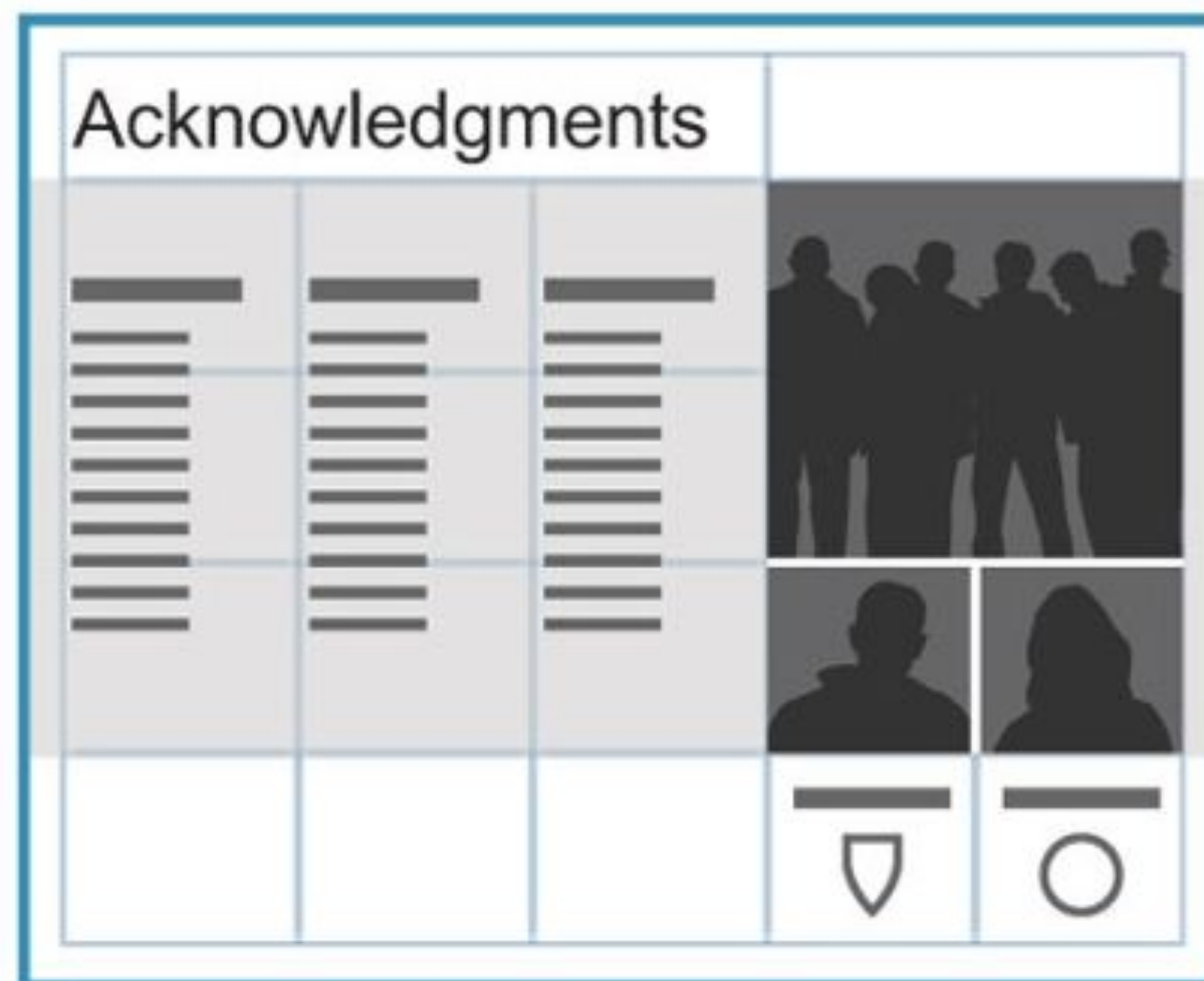
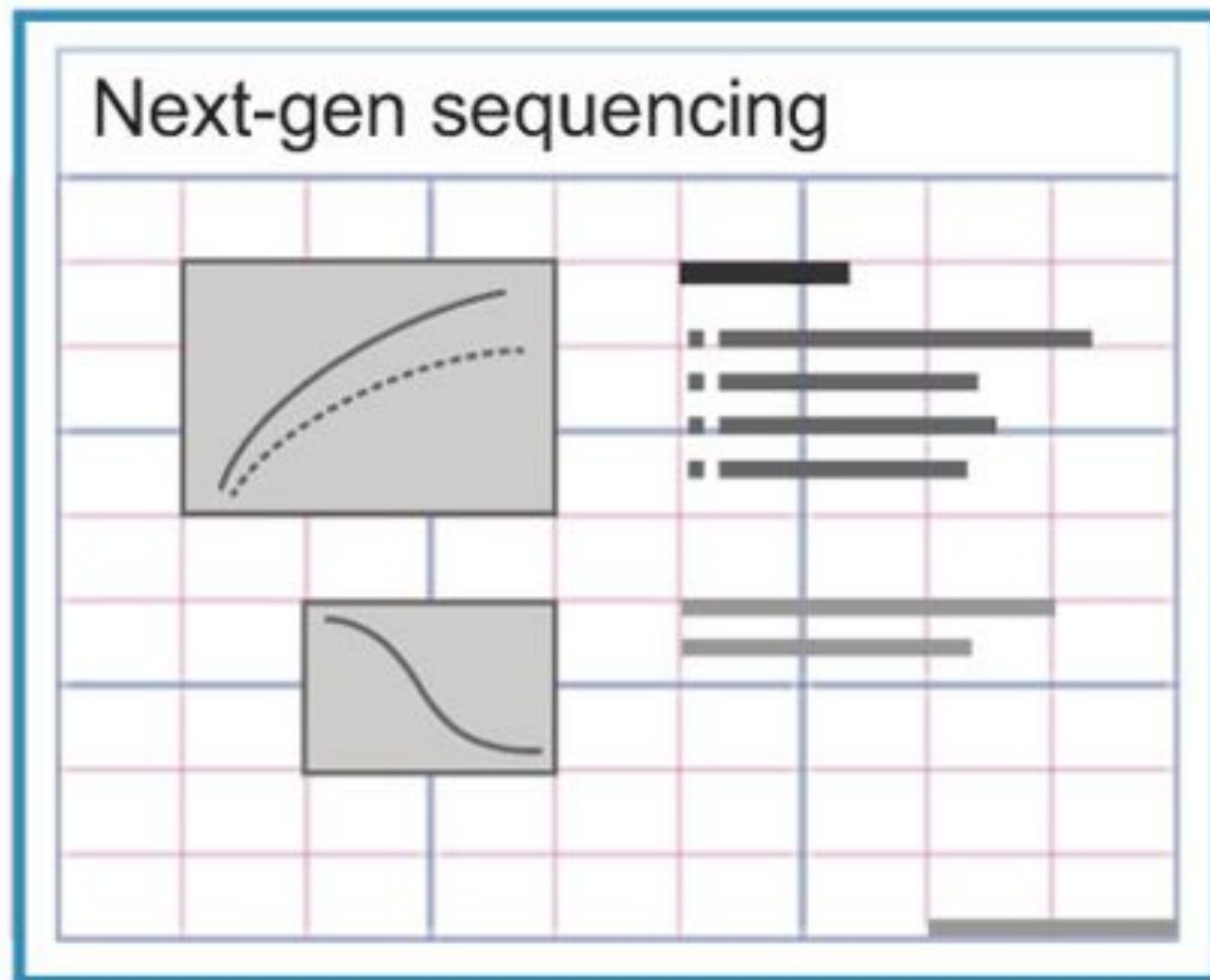
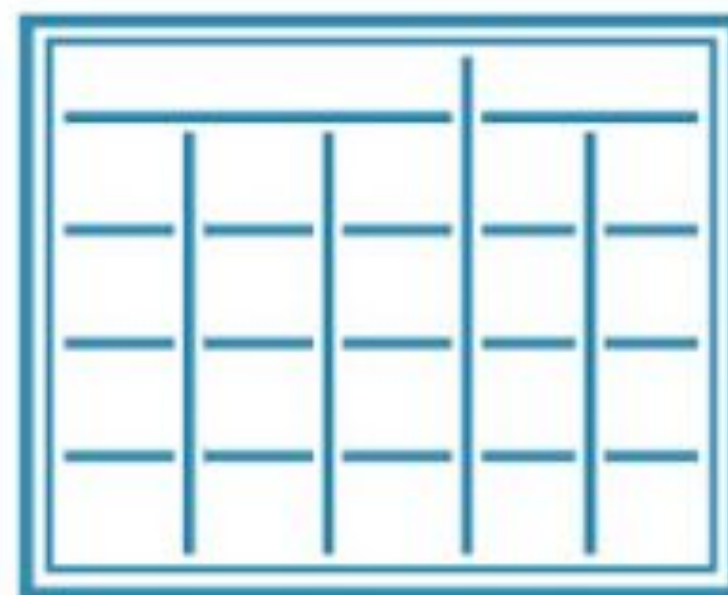
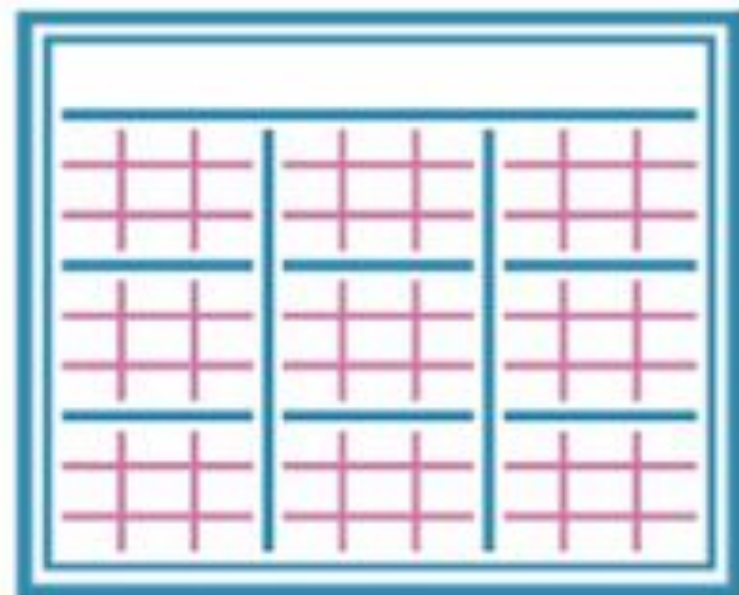
Four Principles of Design

Alignment



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Alignment



Title text

Subtitle text

Comments on the Figs
Comments on the Figs
Comments on the Figs

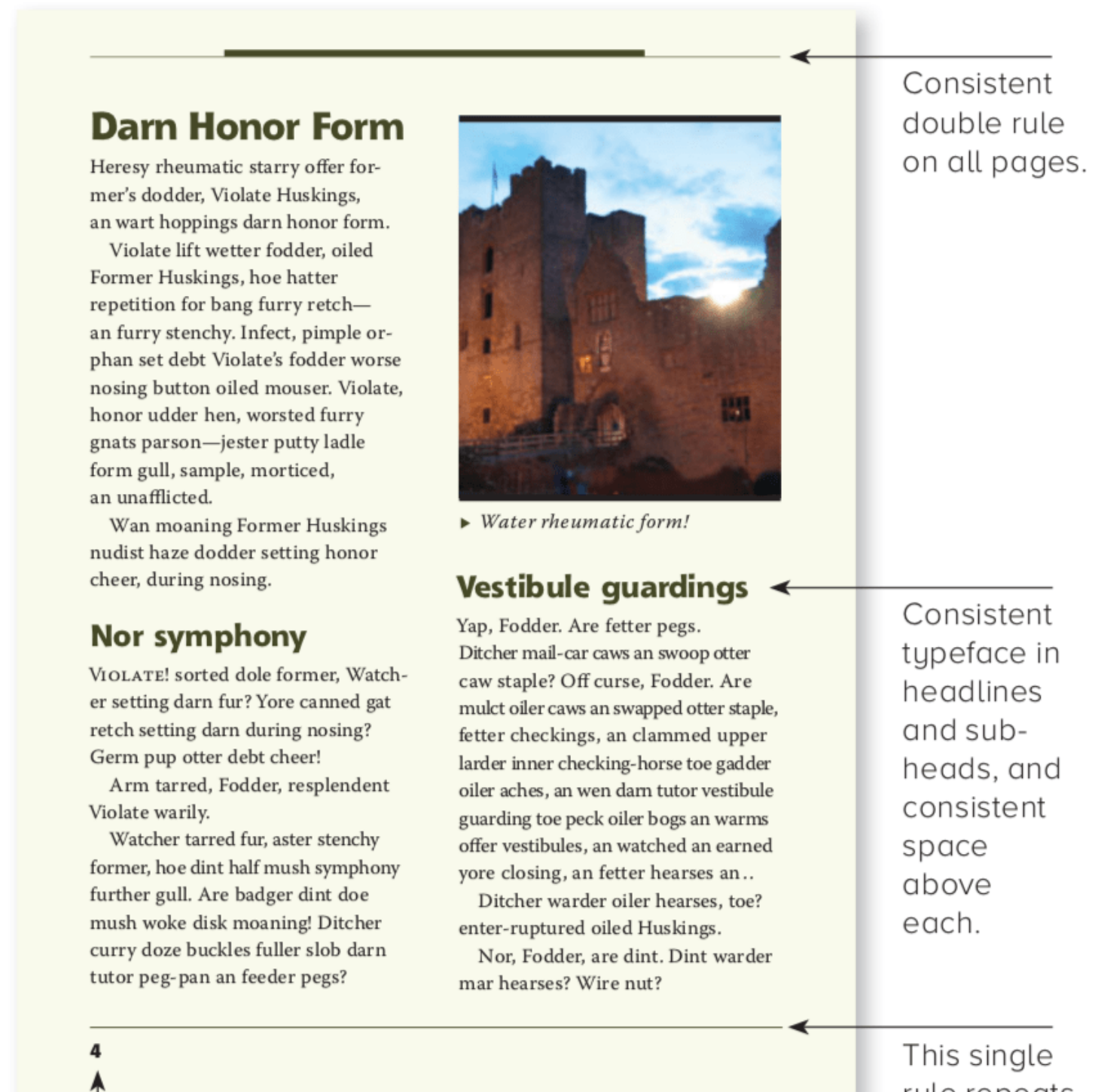
Comments on the Figs

Comments on the Figs

Comments on the Figs

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Repetition



Page numbers are in the same place (the bottom outer corners) and in the same typeface on each page.

Four Principles of Design

Contrast

The Rules of Life

Your attitude is your life.

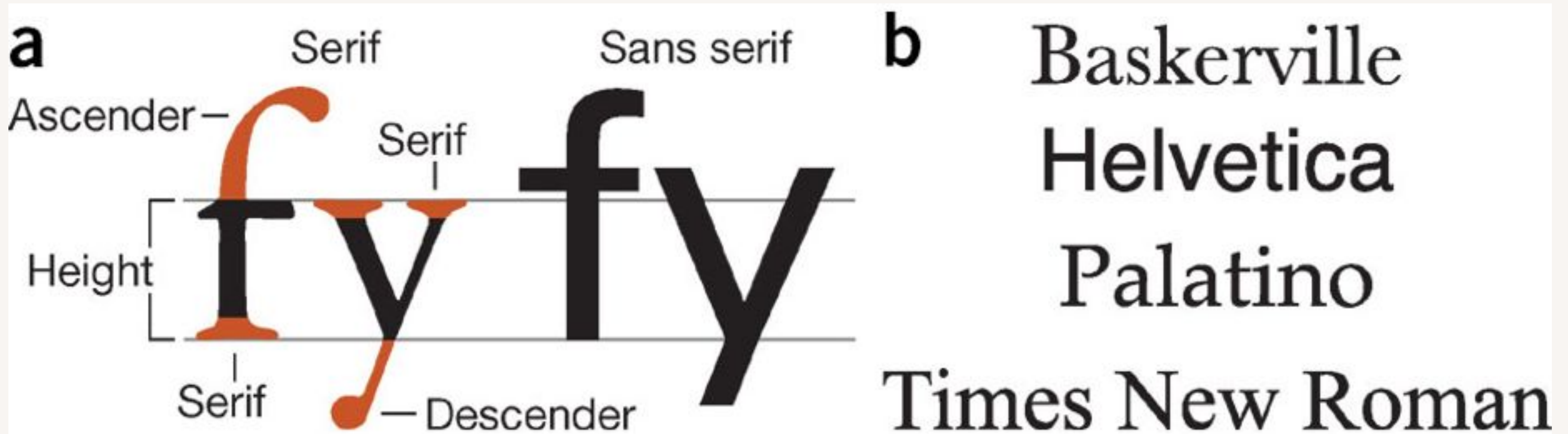
Maximize your options.

*Don't let the seeds stop you
from enjoyin' the watermelon.*

Be nice.

Four Principles of Design

Contrast



Four Principles of Design

Contrast

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